

The red road

If you were to come out here to Austin County and drive down one of our farm to market roads known as FM 2920, you will come upon a stretch of road near New Wedem which is painted red. ~~This piece of~~. This surprising intrusion on the otherwise normal rural scenery has changed a little since it first happened. The color isn't as bright as it once was, having accumulated the wear and abuse of almost two years of traffic. ~~the~~. Still, it is a red road.

It's red enough to make a person sit up and take notice when they are driving along that two lane black top and see it through the windshield of their car.

Folks here in the country know the story by now and they delight in telling it to strangers. The problem is a stranger or newcomer to the area doesn't always hear the real truth of the matter. Some of the red timers take special pleasure in doctoring up what happened and they come up with versions that are so wild and far away from the truth that they are downright embarrassing.

Tom Janacek, who runs the little country store which is down the road about a half mile from the red road, has made up several stories about how the road got its color. He'll size up the stranger who comes in lost and asking for directions and then just wait for the inevitable question about the road. He'll pull the tab on a couple of cans

of beer, and tell whichever version he feels appropriate to the occasion.

Now that road got painted red isn't so strange, really, when you know about Herman Pujaska whose farm that road runs by. Herman is a decendent of Czech immigrants who settled in Texas in the 1840's. This was the era of a large influx of middle-Europeans into Texas. Germans, Poles, Bohemians, all coming to America for a better life. Many of them settled in what is now Austin County. They were mostly rural folks, farmers. Some were merchants and tradesmen who had to learn farming in order to survive. They were a tough group of people who hung on and eventually made it.

Herman's great grandparents came here from Bohemia. They were both hard working, fastidious people who passed these characteristics down to their children and eventually their grandchildren. The women kept their homes spotlessly clean. Wooden floors were hand scrubbed every week. They even swept the dirt in the yard around the house every day. Herman's mother was like all the other women in her family and she raised all seven of her children to feel that next to their belief in God, the most important thing in life was cleanliness, neatness, and order in all that you do.

Herman was a product of this strong parental influence. His farm was one of the best in the county, always well kept, neat and orderly.

Herman plowed the straightest rows you ever saw. He kept all his farm machinery in tip top running order and, when not in use, every piece was lined up nice and neat in a row, straight as an arrow. Whenever the county agent wanted to show someone an outstanding farm, he always took them out to Herman's place. Herman couldn't stand disorder and because of this, the road in front of his gate wound up being painted red. This is how it happened.

Herman's neighbor on the next place over ~~was~~ ^{is} a german fellow named Brenner Gustaf Brenner. He has this huge barn on his farm, one of the biggest in Austin County. It was built back in the time when barns were used to hold a lot of hay. Now, they roll it up into big bundles and just let it stay out in the field. Anyway, ~~Herman's~~ ^{Gustaf's} big barn had needed painting for quite some time. The boards were all weathered and faded pretty bad, except up under the eaves, so he figured it was time that he put a new paint job on that old wood.

He had ordered his paint from the lumber yard in town, planning to take it back with him in his pickup truck. The day he bought the paint, the lumber yard was short of having two five gallon cans to complete the order so they told Gustaf they would just deliver the entire load of paint out to his farm in a few days.

In a couple of days, the paint order was complete and it was made ready to ship out to Gustaf. The driver at the lumber yard loaded his truck with all the things he was scheduled to deliver that day. He had lumber and new screen doors, several aluminium windows, two steel gates and fourteen five gallon cans of red paint for Gustaf Brenner's barn.

The driver started his run and went to the different places to unload. He had finally delivered everything but the paint for Gustaf Brenner's barn. That would be his last stop, after which he planned to run by Janacek's store for a can of beer before driving back into town. He pulled his truck out onto the main road and speeded up to complete his last delivery. He had driven a little over a mile, enough to get his speed up and just before he came to the gate into Herman's farm, a big buck deer broke out of the woods at the side of the road and ran across his path. This unexpected occurrence caused him to swerve his truck and he hit the shoulder of the road. It was soft and low enough to make it difficult for him to steer his truck. He didn't lose complete control, but by the time he got that truck back on the road and running in a straight line, he had dropped every one of those cans of paint out onto the road.

He had neglected to replace the section of tail gate which had been removed at his last stop. The top came off of every one of those cans and as they bounced and rolled on the road, their contents was

spread on the surface in a crazy pattern of splatters and dashes and squiggles. The result looked like one of those modern ~~art~~ paintings that they hang in art galleries.

The truck driver could see in his rear view mirror what had happened so he stopped and pulled off to the side of the road. While he was standing there looking at the mess on the road and wondering how he would explain it to his boss, Herman Pujaska drove down his road and out through the gate onto the main road. He came to an abrupt stop when he saw the paint all over the black top. He climbed out of his truck, staring in disbelief at this violation of his sense of order. His road was a mess! He stood there for several minutes looking up and down at the crazy pattern of oozing red paint. He looked over at the lumber yard truck and its driver, but said nothing to him.

Herman then got back into his truck, drove back up to his barn and soon returned with one of those big paint rollers on a long pole. He got out of his truck, took the paint roller in his hand and walked out onto the highway and began spreading that paint out over the asphalt. Roll, roll, back and forth, back and forth, Herman spread the paint eliminating any area that did not show red. As the crazy pattern of paint began to disappear and gradually give way to a solid field of red color, Herman began to feel better. He even began to smile. By the time he had evenly

covered the road, he was no longer angry. He was, in fact, content at a job well done.

The lumber yard truck driver had long since returned to town, impatient to relate what had taken place. "They'll never believe this", he kept saying to himself.

Herman gathered up all the, by now, empty paint cans and placed them in his truck along with the roller. He looked at the road admiring his work and said, "Well at least it's not so messy anymore." Herman drove back up to the house and called Brenner and asked him to meet him on the road in front of his gate. They had both laughed when Herman told Gustaf what had happened and said, "Well Gus, dere iss your barn." as he pointed at the red road.

Gustaf finally got his barn painted after receiving another sixty gallons of paint. In the ensuing weeks as word began to spread that the road in front of Herman's farm was now red, people would drive by just to look at it and shake their heads.

"Would you just look at that?"

"What in th' hell do you suppose he did that for?" There were those that thought perhaps Herman should take a trip up to the Lusk State Hospital and not come back till he was better.

People from the county commissioner's office came out and wondered what they might do about it. It couldn't be cleaned off. They didn't want to re-top the road. Finally the precinct commissioner said, "Well, damn it, we've got us a red road. 'Probably nothing' like it anywhere else in the whole State of Texas. Paint a white stripe down the middle boys and get on back to town."